



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

the most, from 31 per cent in 2008 to 33 per cent in March 2009, in small towns and lower income houses. And for this growing audience, survival is still an issue. Hence shows with these social issues and small-town stories are ruling.

A fleeting look at the top 10 shows makes the picture clear. Three shows, *Balika Vadhu*, *Bidaai* and *Yeh Rishta...*, have been playing hooky for the number one spot. For the week of April 5 to 11, *Bidaai* claimed number one spot with a TRP of 7.4. *Yeh Rishta...*, a four-month-old rookie, is the story of a young girl from a family in Udaipur who grows up believing in the institution of arranged marriages, followed closely with 7.08 TRP while *Balika Vadhu* settled at number three with a TRP of 5.95. Moreover, the audience no longer owes its loyalty to one channel. If a few years ago, Star Plus was the only channel that featured in the top 10, today Star Plus, Colors and Zee TV are all jostling for space, with NDTV Imagine and Sony making frequent appearances. This is also why no one show has been able to stake its claim on the number

one spot for a long time. In the week of February 22 to 28, *Balika Vadhu* not only claimed the top spot but it also achieved what many soap operas haven't since 2005. The show generated a double digit TRP of 10.2 after 156 weeks. But it slipped soon after. The other shows in the top 10 charts are following the lead. Star Plus' *Sabki Laadli Bebo*, the story of an adopted daughter set in Chandni Chowk launched just a month ago, is already number six with a TRP of 4.09. Colors' *Uttaran* debuted at number 10 in December 2008 and has perched itself at number seven with a TRP of 3.97. Zee TV, the channel that once gave Star Plus a tough battle, is in the process of re-jigging its line-up. They have axed their long-running *Kasamh Se* and have been bolstering *Chhoti Bahu*, currently on number four spot with a TRP of 4.89.

The biggest wake-up call perhaps was that the show that eventually replaced *Kyunki...* on the 10.30 p.m. slot wasn't a soap opera at all. *Aap Ki Kachehri* with Kiran Bedi, a courtroom drama with real people, recently ended its first

Parul Chauhan, 21, and Sara Khan, 19

Ragini and Sadhna on *Bidaai*, Star Plus

These aren't your regular TV stars. The two, slightly shy, slightly uncomfortable girls, Parul Chauhan and Sara Khan, are the leads of *Sapna Babul Ka Bidaai*, a tale of two cousins which has been Star Plus' front-runner since October 2007, making the bahu on prime time wonder why their sacrifices weren't working. From viewers often addressing them by their screen names, Sadhna and Ragini, 19-year-old Khan, who is from Bhopal, and 21-year-old Chauhan, from Lakhimpur Kheri in Uttar Pradesh, are slowly getting used to stardom. Initially, no one believed that they would even see the light of the day on prime time TV. They were too plain, too real, too non-bahu like. "All this while, I was known by my dad's name. Now, everyone asks him if he's Parul's father," says Chauhan, who plays the dusky sister. The two toil for over 10 hours every day for Rs 8,000 to Rs 10,000 every episode. Now that the show is back to its half hour slot, the two have more time, thanks to which Chauhan had been perfecting her dance moves on Sony's *Jhalak Dikhla Jaa*.

CHAUHAN (LEFT)
AND KHAN



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE